

PRIME LOCAL GROWTH

The NAP & Citations Blueprint

Fix the silent Google ranking killer. Find and correct your business listing inconsistencies across every major platform — step by step.

Level: Beginner**Time to implement:** 3–5 hours**Results timeline:** 3–6 weeks

What is NAP and why does it matter? NAP stands for Name, Address, and Phone number. When these details are inconsistent across online directories — even minor differences like "St." vs "Street" or a missing suite number — Google loses confidence in your business's legitimacy and suppresses your local ranking. Fixing NAP inconsistencies is one of the highest-ROI ranking improvements you can make, and almost every local business has them.

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Step 1 — Define Your Master NAP

Before you fix anything, decide on the exact, canonical version of your business information. Every listing will be updated to match this exactly.

Business Name: _____

Address Line 1: _____

Address Line 2 (suite/unit): _____

City: _____ **State:** _____ **ZIP:** _____

Phone: _____

Website URL: _____

Business Hours: _____

Common mistakes to avoid in your master NAP

- ☐ **Business name must match your legal/signage name**
Don't add keywords (e.g. "Best Plumber San Antonio" as your business name). Google flags this as spam.
- ☐ **Use one consistent phone format**
Choose either (210) 555-1234 or 210-555-1234 and use it everywhere.
- ☐ **Abbreviations: pick one and stick to it**
"St" vs "Street," "Ave" vs "Avenue," "Blvd" vs "Boulevard" — choose one and never mix.
- ☐ **Suite numbers: always include if applicable**
"Suite 200" vs "#200" vs "Ste 200" — pick one format.
- ☐ **Use your local phone number, not an 800 number**
Local numbers rank better in local search.

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Step 2 — Run Your Audit (Free Tools)

Before you start fixing, find out where your listings exist and where the errors are. Use these free tools:

Tool	URL	What it checks
Moz Local Check	moz.com/local/search	Finds all your listings and flags inconsistencies

BrightLocal Citation Tracker	brightlocal.com	Free audit — shows all citations and errors
Whitespark Citation Finder	whitespark.ca	Finds citations competitors have that you don't
Google Search	google.com	Search your business name + city — manually check top results

Manual audit checklist

Google each of these and verify your listing matches your Master NAP:

- ☐ Search: "[Business Name] [City]" — check the top 10 results
- ☐ Search: "[Phone Number]" — see what listings come up
- ☐ Search: "[Address]" — verify what's listed for your address

Pro tip: Take a screenshot of every inconsistency you find before fixing it. This gives you before/after proof of your work and helps you track which platforms you've already corrected.

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Step 3 — The Top 40 Directories (Priority Order)

Fix these in priority order. The Tier 1 directories carry the most weight with Google's algorithm. Don't move to Tier 2 until Tier 1 is complete.

Tier 1 — Critical (fix first)

Directory	URL	Why it matters
Google Business Profile	business.google.com	The source of truth — all others are secondary

Apple Maps	mapsconnect.apple.com	Powers Siri and iPhone "near me" searches
Bing Places	bingplaces.com	Powers Bing, Yahoo, and AOL local search
Yelp	biz.yelp.com	High domain authority + Yelp powers many third-party directories
Facebook Business	facebook.com/business	Social authority + discovery platform
BBB (Better Business Bureau)	bbb.org	Trust signal; high domain authority

Tier 2 — High Priority

Directory	URL
Yellow Pages (YP.com)	yp.com
Foursquare	foursquare.com/add-place
Angi (formerly Angie's List)	pro.angi.com
HomeAdvisor	homeadvisor.com/c.html
Thumbtack	thumbtack.com/pro
Nextdoor	business.nextdoor.com
Houzz (home services)	houzz.com/pro
Chamber of Commerce	Your local chamber's website

Tier 3 — Data Aggregators (most impactful per hour spent)

These four services feed your business data to hundreds of smaller directories. Fix your listing on these and the data propagates automatically over 4–8 weeks.

Aggregator	URL	Feeds data to
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Data Axle (Localeze)	business.data-axle.com	500+ directories and apps
Foursquare	foursquare.com	Apple Maps, Uber, 100+ apps
Neustar Localeze	neustarlocaleze.biz	Navigation systems, voice search
GPS Network (TomTom / Garmin)	mapmaker.tomtom.com	Navigation devices and apps

Tier 4 — Industry-Specific (add based on your business type)

Industry	Key directories to claim
Home Services (HVAC, Plumbing, etc.)	Angi, HomeAdvisor, Houzz, Porch, Thumbtack
Medical / Dental	Healthgrades, Zocdoc, Vitals, WebMD, RateMDs
Legal	Avvo, FindLaw, Justia, Lawyers.com, Martindale
Restaurant / Food	TripAdvisor, OpenTable, Grubhub, DoorDash, Zomato
Auto Repair	RepairPal, CarTalk, AutoMD, Mechanic Advisor



Step 4 — How to Claim and Fix Each Listing

If the listing exists but has wrong info:

- ☐ **Claim the listing**
— most directories have a "Claim this business" button. You'll need to verify via phone call, postcard, or email.

- ☐ **Update all fields to match your Master NAP exactly**
— name, address, phone, website, hours, categories, description.
- ☐ **Add photos if the platform allows**
— same photos you use on GBP. Consistency signals legitimacy.
- ☐ **Note the date of your update**
— some directories take 2–4 weeks to update publicly.

If the listing doesn't exist yet:

- ☐ **Create a new listing**
— use your Master NAP exactly. Don't copy/paste between directories without checking for formatting differences.
- ☐ **Write a unique description for each major platform**
— don't copy the exact same text everywhere. Unique descriptions perform better.
- ☐ **Use the same category on each platform**
as you use on GBP where possible.

Duplicate listings: If you find duplicate listings for your business, claim both and then request the duplicate be removed. On Google, use the "Suggest an edit" feature to flag the duplicate. On Yelp, contact their support directly.

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Step 5 — Track Your Progress

Use this tracking sheet. Update it as you go. A completed citation audit is a permanent asset for your business.

Directory	Tier	Status	Issues found	Date fixed
Google Business Profile	Tier 1	☐ Done		

Apple Maps	Tier 1	☐ Done
Bing Places	Tier 1	☐ Done
Yelp	Tier 1	☐ Done
Facebook Business	Tier 1	☐ Done
BBB	Tier 1	☐ Done
Yellow Pages	Tier 2	☐ Done
Foursquare	Tier 2	☐ Done
Angi	Tier 2	☐ Done
Nextdoor	Tier 2	☐ Done
Data Axle	Tier 3	☐ Done

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Monthly Maintenance Checklist

After your initial audit, ongoing maintenance takes 15–20 minutes per month.

- ☐ **Run a Moz Local scan**
— check for any new inconsistencies or duplicate listings that may have appeared.
- ☐ **Check for new reviews on Yelp and BBB**
— respond within 48 hours.
- ☐ **Verify your hours are current**
— especially around holidays or if you've changed your schedule.
- ☐ **Check for any new duplicate listings**
— data aggregators occasionally create new listings. Remove immediately.
- ☐ **Update all platforms if any business info changes**

— moved location, new phone number, new website. Update every platform within 48 hours of any change.

Results timeline: You'll typically see Google ranking movement 3–6 weeks after completing your Tier 1 and Tier 2 fixes. Data aggregator updates take 4–8 weeks to propagate. Be patient — this is a compounding investment that keeps paying off.

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